Maternal Mental Health, Family Wellness & Community Resilience

Introduction

There is an opportunity to establish a community-based nonprofit organization dedicated to improving maternal mental health and strengthening families, with an initial focus on Black mothers, Haitian and other immigrant women, and underserved families throughout Boston and Greater Boston.

The organization would be grounded in the professional experience, research, and community perspective of Dr. Colette Dieujuste, RN, PhD, while creating a platform through which that expertise can be translated into meaningful community services, education, partnerships, and advocacy.

At the center of the concept is a simple but important understanding: maternal mental health is not an isolated health issue. It is deeply connected to family relationships, culture, social support, economic circumstances, access to healthcare, and the overall stability of the household.

Dr. Collette's research examining the lived experiences of Haitian immigrant women with postpartum depression provides an important foundation for this approach. Her research identified the experience of mothers feeling disconnected as a result of limited support, partner conflict, and separation from familiar culture, while also identifying pathways toward feeling reconnected through seeking help, spirituality, and resilience.

This perspective can become a defining principle of the organization: helping mothers move from isolation and disconnection toward support, connection, wellness, and resilience.

The organization would seek to create a trusted environment where women and families can access information, support, navigation, connections to appropriate care, and practical resources without fear of stigma or judgment.

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Core Program Areas

1. Maternal Mental Health & Postpartum Support

Maternal mental health would serve as the foundation of the organization's work.

The program would focus on increasing awareness of postpartum depression and anxiety, helping mothers recognize when they need support, reducing stigma, and connecting women to appropriate resources and professional care.

Potential services and activities would include:

- Maternal mental-health education
- Postpartum depression and anxiety screening
- Emotional wellness assessments
- Peer support groups
- Maternal wellness and healing workshops
- Trauma-informed support
- Referrals to licensed behavioral-health providers
- Community education and stigma-reduction activities

The organization would emphasize culturally responsive approaches that recognize the influence of culture, immigration experiences, family relationships, spirituality, and community on a mother's mental-health experience.

The objective is not simply to identify symptoms, but to help women understand their experiences, feel supported, and successfully connect with the care and resources they need.

2. Community Health & Resource Navigation

Many mothers and families face significant difficulty navigating healthcare and social-service systems.

The organization would provide a trusted community connection between families and the systems designed to support them.

Navigation assistance could include connections to:

- Prenatal and postpartum healthcare
- Pediatric care
- Health insurance and benefits
- WIC and SNAP
- Transportation resources
- Behavioral-health services
- Housing resources
- Childcare and family services
- Emergency and community resources

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Community navigators would help families understand available resources, make appropriate connections, and overcome practical barriers that can prevent them from receiving care.

This component would allow the organization to address an important gap between having resources available and actually being able to access them.

3. Family Wellness & Support

Maternal wellbeing is closely connected to the wellbeing of the entire family.

The organization would therefore take a family-centered approach that recognizes the importance of fathers, partners, grandparents, and other members of a mother's support system.

Programming could include:

- Parenting education
- Family-support workshops
- Father and partner engagement
- Family wellness activities
- Connections to food and basic-needs resources
- Infant and maternal resource support
- Housing and family stabilization referrals
- Community support groups

The goal would be to help families better understand maternal mental health, strengthen support systems, and create healthier environments for mothers and children.

4. Economic & Family Stability

Over time, the organization can also recognize the relationship between maternal wellbeing and economic stability.

Pregnancy and postpartum challenges can affect employment, education, household income, and a parent's ability to pursue long-term goals.

The organization could connect participating families with:

- Workforce-readiness resources
- Career counseling
- Educational opportunities

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- Financial-literacy programs
- Employment resources
- Entrepreneurship and economic-development opportunities

This component would complement the organization's maternal-health mission by recognizing that healthy families also require pathways toward economic stability and independence.

Vision for the Organization

The long-term vision is to create a trusted, culturally responsive maternal and family wellness organization serving underserved communities throughout Massachusetts.

The organization would begin in Boston and Greater Boston, establishing strong relationships with mothers, families, healthcare providers, community organizations, and other trusted institutions. As the model develops, it could expand to additional communities experiencing significant maternal-health disparities and limited access to culturally responsive services.

Ultimately, the organization should become more than a provider of individual services. It should become a community resource and center of connection—bringing together maternal mental health, healthcare navigation, family support, cultural responsiveness, and pathways toward greater family stability.

The vision is to create an environment where mothers do not have to navigate postpartum challenges alone; where cultural and community experiences are understood rather than overlooked; and where seeking help is viewed as a strength.

Healthy mothers create stronger families, and stronger families create healthier communities.

Through a culturally responsive and family-centered model, the organization can help mothers move from disconnection to connection, from isolation to support, and from vulnerability to resilience—while building a foundation for healthier outcomes for mothers, children, and future generations.

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